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Vile Parle

10.30 p.m.: High-intensity blast in a taxi, possibly a diversionary attack to spread the security forces thin



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Metro Cinema

Midnight: Terrorists escape in a police van from the cinema after gunning down ATS chief Hemant Karkare

**TARGET MUMBAI**

March 12, 1993

Thirteen blasts across the city claim 257 lives

August 25, 2003

Twin blasts at Gateway of India and Zaveri Bazaar kill 50 people

July 11, 2006

Seven blasts at seven locations in local trains across the city kill 181



BODIES OF DINERS KILLED BY TERRORISTS AT THE TAJ MAHAL HOTEL

death toll was 102, with another 300 injured.

That this was the best planned, organised, financed and most successful terror attack in India was evident from the fact that 20 hours after the first shots rang out, the terrorists, were still holed up in the Taj Hotel, the Oberoi Trident and a residential building in Nariman Point housing Jewish tenants. The two dozen terrorists held hostages and kept security forces at bay. Mumbai is no stranger to terror but this was the most devastating in terms of scale, preparation, targets and global impact. Everything pointed to the involvement of a major international terror group (the claims by Deccan Mujahideen were dismissed by police), probably the Pakistan-based Lashkar-e-Toiba but orchestrated by Al-Qaeda.

Hostages who managed to escape said that the terrorists asked hotel guests whether they were American or British before taking them hostage. The Taj and Trident are two of Mumbai's most recognisable landmarks, akin to New York's Twin Towers, and attract the majority of high-profile guests from India and abroad. European diplomats, American and British tourists, top industrialists and executives were among those in residence. Their eyewitness accounts after they emerged from the Taj showed what a meticulously planned and cold-blooded operation this was, bearing

the hallmarks of an international outfit with access to boats, inside intelligence, sophisticated weapons and explosives.

The terror drama started shortly after 9 p.m., a time when restaurants and hotels are at their most crowded. The suicide squads who had arrived in the city via rubber boats from the sea opened fire and lobbed grenades at 10 different locations. After the 1993 serial blasts, this is the most audacious strike. From diners and residents at luxury hotels to commuters at Chhatrapati Shivaji Terminus railway station, and people on the streets, everyone had become a target. Within minutes, the station resembled a graveyard.

The terrorists entered from the Gateway of India and Nariman Point in boats and launched a triangular attack. One team entered Trident Hotel and opened fire in the restaurant's lobby; another team fired indiscriminately at Leopold's Café in Colaba and then entered the Taj Hotel. As confusion reigned, the terrorists hijacked police jeeps to create more mayhem. An Anti-Terrorist Squad (ATS) team led by its head Hemant Karkare chased them to Cama Hospital, where he, encounter specialist Vijay Salaskar and another colleague were killed.

Two terrorists were killed in a chase near Girgaum as they were trying to escape in a silver Skoda. One was reportedly arrested the